WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital

NEW CALEDONIA

Oceania

Information current as of November 2026

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Nouméa and Greater Nouméa (South Province)	Capital and main economic centre, home to the Congress, the government, the High Commission, the main port and the SLN Doniambo nickel smelter	Services, logistics, construction, finance, nickel processing
Southern Lagoon / Prony (South Province)	Site of the Prony Resources hydrometallurgical plant, now for sale, producing nickel products for battery supply chains	Nickel and cobalt processing, battery materials, port services
Voh–Koniambo (North Province)	Koniambo Nickel smelter, idle since 2024 and seeking a buyer, with Indian, Emirati and Chinese groups showing interest in the sector	Nickel metallurgy, mining services, energy
Mining centres across the main island	Ore extraction rose 24% in 2025, supporting exports while the plants are restructured	Nickel mining, ore exports, equipment and logistics
Île des Pins and the Loyalty Islands	Leading cruise and leisure destinations; cruise passengers rose 31% to 250,924 in 2025	Cruise and eco-tourism, hospitality, local services
North Province (Koné and the north-east coast)	Provincial capital Koné leads diversification efforts away from nickel in a region shaped by the KNS shutdown	Agriculture, aquaculture, tourism, public works
Lagoons and Exclusive Economic Zone	Extensive marine area underpinning the government's blue-economy diversification goal	Aquaculture (shrimp), fisheries, marine tourism, research

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Governing relationship: a French overseas collectivity with special status (sui generis) under Title XIII of the French Constitution and the 1998 Nouméa Accord; France retains defence, currency, justice and public order, while New Caledonia sets its own tax, labour and economic law
- Three Provinces (South, North and Loyalty Islands) lead economic development, investment support and land matters, alongside the New Caledonian government and its economic services
- Local tax regime: 30% corporate income tax (15% for smaller companies) and 35% for mining and metallurgy, with a 15-year tax-stabilisation regime available for mining projects
- Productive-investment tax support under local law, which may be combined with French national overseas investment schemes, subject to conditions and approvals

- Currency: the CFP franc, issued by the IEOM and pegged at 1,000 XPF = €8.38, with convertibility guaranteed by the French Republic
- EU status: one of the EU's overseas countries and territories (OCTs), outside the single market and customs union but associated with the EU and eligible for EU cooperation funding; French nationals living there are EU citizens
- French State and AFD support: more than XPF 62 billion announced for 2026–2027 and a 2027–2031 financial contract under negotiation by end-2026

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

New Caledonia in November 2026 is a French-law, euro-pegged economy beginning to recover from the May 2024 unrest, with the world-class nickel resources and lagoon tourism assets that underpin its long-term potential. GDP grew 0.7% in 2025 to XPF 915 billion after a 13.5% fall in 2024, driven by a 13% rise in export volumes; inflation was contained at 1.1%, and the IEOM business-climate indicator rose 13 points to 89. Metallurgical output rose 35.4% to 72,213 tonnes of contained nickel, and cruise passengers increased 31%. The June 2026 elections produced a new majority, and in August Milakulo Tukumuli became President of the Government with a six-month roadmap to restore pension and health finances, back credible nickel investment offers and diversify into tourism, agriculture, the blue economy and digital services. The French State has announced over XPF 62 billion of support for 2026–2027.

New Caledonia's main structural challenge is restoring investment and public finances while its institutional future is settled. Investment fell 12.5% in 2025, private salaried jobs were 18.4% lower than two years earlier, public debt has reached about XPF 188 billion, and the nickel sector depends on new owners: Koniambo is idle and Prony Resources is for sale. The July 2025 Bougival agreement, which proposed a "State of New Caledonia" within the French Republic with its own nationality, was rejected by the FLNKS and then by the French National Assembly on 2 April 2026, and status talks are expected to resume only after France's 2027 elections. Mitigation is strong: French and EU frameworks, the CFP franc's fixed euro peg and State financial backing provide stability, and a 2027–2031 financial contract is under negotiation. For investors, nickel restructuring, reconstruction and diversification offer entry points at attractive valuations.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Unresolved institutional status	The Bougival agreement's constitutional bill was rejected on 2 April 2026, and talks on New Caledonia's future status are not expected before France's 2027 elections	Existing Nouméa Accord institutions continue to function under French law; structure contracts under French and local law and monitor the timetable for renewed talks
Nickel sector restructuring	Koniambo is idle, Prony Resources is for sale and SLN relies on State support, while nickel prices hit five-year lows in 2025	New owners are being sought with French State involvement; acquirers with long-term commitment can secure world-class resources at a cyclical low
Public and social finances	Debt of about XPF 188 billion and deficits in pensions and health insurance require reform and State support	The 2027–2031 State–territory financial contract and the government's reform roadmap provide a path to sustainability
Weak investment and credit	Investment fell 12.5% in 2025 and bank credit outstanding fell 6.3%	Business investment credit rose 5.8% in 2025; AFD and Bpifrance co-financing can support viable projects
Social cohesion and security	The May 2024 unrest caused 14 deaths and over €2.2 billion of damage, and population has declined	Security has been restored under French authority; community engagement, local hiring and insurance planning support project continuity
Tourism recovery	Long-stay visitors totalled 58,421 in 2025, still well below pre-crisis levels	Cruise traffic is growing strongly, creating a base for hotel, excursion and aviation investment as confidence returns
High costs and import dependence	Imports of XPF 223.2 billion far exceed non-nickel exports, raising input costs	Local processing, renewable energy and agri-food import substitution offer direct opportunities

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

New Caledonia's risk profile combines the legal and monetary stability of the French Republic with a period of economic recovery and institutional uncertainty. Contracts are enforceable under French and local law, the CFP franc is pegged to the euro with convertibility guaranteed by France, and the French State is providing large-scale financial support. Growth resumed in 2025 at 0.7%, and the new government formed in August 2026 has set out a reform roadmap. The main considerations are the unresolved political status, since the Bougival agreement was rejected by the French National Assembly in April 2026 and talks are expected only after France's 2027 elections; the restructuring of the nickel industry; and the territory's debt and social-security deficits. Each is being addressed through State–territory financial contracts, the search for committed nickel investors and fiscal reform. Investors should take local legal and tax advice, engage with the Provinces and the High Commission, and build community relations into project planning; patient capital can benefit from attractive entry valuations and strong public support for recovery.

MARKET ACCESS

As an overseas country and territory associated with the European Union, New Caledonia is outside the EU single market and customs union, sets its own customs duties and consumption tax, and benefits from preferential access to the EU market and EU cooperation funding, while residents hold French and EU citizenship. Nickel accounts for about 90% of exports, which totalled XPF 135.2 billion in 2025, with export volumes up 9.8%. The territory is a full member of the Pacific Islands Forum and has air and sea links to Australia, New Zealand, mainland France and neighbouring Pacific states including Vanuatu, Fiji and Wallis and Futuna. Nouméa's port and La Tontouta International Airport are the main gateways, and growing cruise traffic, with 81 ship calls in 2025, connects the islands to Australian and regional tourism markets.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Government of New Caledonia (President Milakulo Tukumuli)	Collegial executive elected in August 2026; leads the recovery roadmap, nickel strategy, budget and negotiations with the State	Primary reference point for territorial economic policy and major projects
High Commission of the Republic (High Commissioner Jacques Billant)	Represents the French State; leads State negotiations on the 2027–2031 financial contract and oversees State competences	Key interlocutor on State financing, security and national policy
Provinces (South, North and Loyalty Islands)	Hold economic development powers, provide investment incentives and manage provincial land and mining permits	Standard first point of contact for project support and siting
IEOM (Institut d'émission d'outre-mer)	Issues the CFP franc and acts as the central-bank arm in the French Pacific territories, monitoring banks and the economy	Authoritative source of economic, banking and business-climate intelligence
Congress of New Caledonia	Territorial legislature that votes local tax and economic laws and the budget, which must be adopted for 2027 by end-2026	Relevant for tax, mining and economic legislation
Nickel producers (SLN, Prony Resources, Koniambo Nickel)	The three metallurgical plants at the centre of the sector's restructuring and sale processes	Counterparts for nickel investment, offtake and supply-chain opportunities
Agence française de développement (AFD) and Bpifrance	French public financiers for public, social and private-sector projects, and partners in economic analysis with the IEOM	Co-financing partners for infrastructure, energy and business investment

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The Chamber of Commerce and Industry of New Caledonia and employer bodies such as the MEDEF-NC and CPME-NC represent business and are in regular dialogue with the government and the State. The Provinces' economic development departments support investors, and Business France and Team France Invest can connect international investors with French public networks. AFD, Bpifrance and the French State are the principal financing partners, and the European Union supports the territory as an overseas country and territory. As a member of the Pacific Islands Forum, New Caledonia also offers channels to Australia, New Zealand and Pacific neighbours.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

New Caledonia suits patient investors who value French legal protection and a euro-pegged currency: mining and metals groups and battery-material buyers able to take long-term positions in the nickel restructuring; renewable-energy developers helping to lower power costs for industry; tourism and cruise investors targeting the lagoons, Île des Pins and the Loyalty Islands; and agri-food, aquaculture and blue-economy businesses replacing imports and serving Pacific markets. Construction and engineering firms can benefit from reconstruction and State-supported public investment.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage the Provinces and the government
Open dialogue with the relevant Province and the government's economic services to identify incentives, sites and priority sectors.

STEP 2: Take local legal and tax advice
Confirm the applicable corporate tax rate, mining stabilisation options and productive-investment tax support, and how French overseas schemes may apply.

STEP 3: Assess nickel-sector opportunities
Follow the sale processes for Koniambo and Prony Resources and SLN's restructuring, working with the State and Provinces on credible long-term offers.

STEP 4: Line up public co-financing
Approach AFD, Bpifrance and EU OCT programmes, and track the 2027–2031 State–territory financial contract.

STEP 5: Plan for the institutional timetable
Monitor status talks expected after France's 2027 elections and build community engagement and local employment into project design.